

The Curlew

NEWSLETTER OF THE MILLBROOK VALLEY NATURALISTS

No. 41

Spring 2027

Free to members



FIELD TRIP REPORT

Late snow and low cloud on the range above the lake, photographed on the second morning of the trip. Photo: Grand Teton National Park, public domain.

OUR SPRING TRIP

Six days, forty-one species and one very patient bus driver

By the trips committee

Twenty-two members set off in the dark on the first of April, with flasks, three spotting scopes and a printed list of every bird anyone had ever reported from the lake. We came back with forty-one species, a dozen rolls of film's worth of photographs on our phones, and a new respect for the people who keep the visitor centre's feeders full through the winter.

The weather was against us for the first two days. Cloud sat on the mountains and rain came across the water in curtains, so we spent most of the first afternoon in the hide at the north end, which turned out to be the best decision of the week. A pair of trumpeter swans worked the reeds for an hour in front of us, close enough to hear them grumbling to each other.

> *"The first curlew of the year is a better clock than any calendar."*
>
> MARGARET ELLISON, FOUNDING MEMBER

On the third day the cloud lifted, and so did the birds. By lunchtime we had added sandhill cranes, a merlin hunting low over the sage, and a flock of more than three hundred American pipits that rose from the meadow all at once and settled again as if nothing had happened. Our youngest member, aged nine, found the trip's only long-eared owl by asking why that branch had eyes.

The highlight, for most of us, came on the last evening. Standing on the dike with the sun going down, we heard the call before we saw the bird: the long rising whistle of a long-billed curlew, back from the coast for the summer. It flew over us, landed in the wet grass a hundred metres away and started feeding as if it had never left.

Thank you to everyone who came, to the visitor centre staff, and to Dale, who drove the bus, never once complained about stopping for a hawk on a fence post, and has asked to come again next year.

NEXT YEAR

The committee is already planning a trip to the coast in early autumn, when the shorebirds are heading south. If you would like to help, see the members' corner on page 4.

COUNTS AND TRENDS

The migration report

Compiled from members' records, 1 January to 31 March



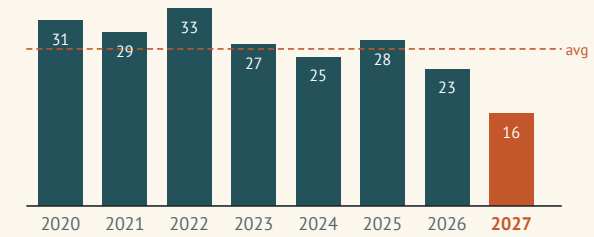
A long-billed curlew on the mudflats. Its bill can be longer than its body. Photo: U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service, public domain.

Members sent in 1,184 records this quarter, our highest total since the club began collecting them on paper cards in 1987. Most came through the online form, but we still receive a handful of postcards every month, and we still enter every one of them by hand.

The headline is good news. Long-billed curlews returned to the valley eleven days earlier than the average of the last twenty years, and the first breeding pair was reported on the old airfield on the twenty-third of March. Numbers of wintering swans were also up, helped by a mild February that kept the river free of ice.

Not every trend points the same way. Counts of meadowlarks fell for the fourth year running, and the regional survey team has asked clubs across the state to record every singing male they hear between April and June. Details of how to take part are in the box below.

First curlew of the year (day of March)



QUARTER AT A GLANCE

Species	Records	Change
Long-billed curlew	64	▲ 38%
Trumpeter swan	211	▲ 12%
Sandhill crane	148	▲ 5%
Western meadowlark	37	▼ 21%
Northern harrier	52	0%
American pipit	96	▼ 9%

COUNT A MEADOWLARK

Walk the same route once a fortnight between April and June, stop every 500 metres for three minutes, and write down every meadowlark you hear. Send your sheets to the records officer; blank forms are on the club noticeboard.

As always, thank you to everyone who sent records. Every card and every form adds to a picture of the valley that now stretches back forty years, and that picture is only as good as the people who fill it in.

FAR FROM HOME

Still flying at seventy



Laysan albatrosses at Midway Atoll, where the oldest known wild bird returns to nest. Photo: Kiah Walker, U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service, public domain.

At our February meeting, our guest speaker told the story of Wisdom, a Laysan albatross first fitted with a leg band at Midway Atoll in the Pacific in 1956. She was already an adult then, which makes her the oldest known wild bird in the world. Decades later she is still coming back to the same island to nest, after flying, by one estimate, millions of kilometres over the ocean.

Albatrosses pair for life and take turns on the nest while the other partner feeds at sea, sometimes for weeks at a time. They can sleep on the wing, glide for hours without a single flap, and smell food on the water from kilometres away. Our speaker's advice for anyone hoping to see one: be patient, bring a good coat, and learn to love boats.

The talk raised £214 for the seabird recovery programme. Thank you to everyone who bought a raffle ticket, and congratulations to the winner of the albatross jigsaw puzzle, which has one thousand pieces and, we are told, at least nine hundred of them blue.

VOLUNTEERS

A new hide for the north marsh



A viewing hide like the one we hope to build. Photo: Steve Hillebrand, U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service, public domain.

After three years of fundraising and one very long planning meeting, the town council has agreed to let us replace the old hide at the north marsh. The new one will have a ramp for wheelchairs and pushchairs, viewing slots at two heights, and a fixed scope that children can reach.

We need volunteers for four building weekends in June. No experience is needed, only gloves and good humour; the club will provide tools, lunch and an expert carpenter who has promised to teach anyone who asks how to cut a joint that does not wobble.

COMING UP

APR 19 — **Dawn chorus walk.** Meet at the church gate at 5:30. Breakfast at the café afterwards for anyone still awake.

MAY 21 — **Evening talk: moths.** With a live trap demonstration in the car park after dark.

MAY 03 — **Beginners' morning.** Binoculars to borrow, and nobody minds how many times you ask what that brown bird was.

JUN 07 — **First building weekend** at the north marsh. Sign up with the volunteer coordinator.



Members' corner

Swans at sunset at a migratory bird refuge. Photo: Jeff Adams, U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service, public domain. The tint is drawn with a multiply blend, the title with a screen blend.

PHOTOGRAPH OF THE SEASON



A pectoral sandpiper in the evening light. Photo: U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service, public domain.

This season's competition had a record thirty-four entries. The judges chose this quiet portrait of a pectoral sandpiper, almost hidden in the grass, because, in their words, "it rewards anyone who takes the time to look". Entries for the summer competition close on the last day of June; the theme is "water".

LETTERS

To the editor: I was delighted to see the barn owl box on the cover of the winter issue. I am pleased to report that the box in my orchard, built at the November workshop, now has a resident. She hisses at me every morning and I could not be happier. — *A grateful member*

To the editor: Could the club consider a second beginners' morning on a weekday, for those of us who work weekends? — *A shift worker* **The committee replies:** Yes. See the events list for dates once they are confirmed.

JOIN US

Name

Address

Email

Membership: ☐ Individual £12 ☐ Family £18 ☐ Junior £4

The Curlew is written and edited by volunteers. Opinions are the writers' own. The Millbrook Valley Naturalists and everyone named in this newsletter are invented for a sample document.